

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

Nouns 1

Part 2: Number



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What is nominal number?

Nominal number is a grammatical category that tells *how many* of a thing there is. In English, we have two grammatical numbers: *singular* (there is one) and *plural* (there is more than one). Although "singular" and "plural" are the most common categories of grammatical number, they are certainly not the only categories possible.

Dual number is used in many languages to indicate exactly two of a thing. Several languages only have dual markers for things that naturally come in pairs like eyes and hands. *Trial* is similar in that it indicates exactly three of something, but has so far only been found in pronouns. A handful of languages have a vaguer category called the *paucal* number to indicate that there are "a few" of something.

Other languages split the number categories between "singulative" and "collective." For example, the English word "rice" really refers to a group of rice grains - a collective. If we were to pull one out, we'd call it a *grain* of rice. Some languages have a dedicated marker for *singulative* items from a *collective*. It's kind of like the opposite of a singular-plural distinction where "rice" would be the base form and, say, "ricelet" would be a singulative affix for a single grain of rice. One language that does this is Welsh, which considers words like *moch* (pigs) as collective and become singulative with a suffix: *moch-yn* (pig). So far, no known language uses an entirely singulative-collective system. Instead, they apply that pattern to only a certain subset of nouns, but the rest of the nouns have a singular-plural distinction.

Some languages also have what's called an *associative plural*. These are most often applied to people to mean "This person and other people associated with this person," kind of like how we use "*et al.*" to refer to academic writings with several authors or how some restaurants will call you to your table as "{person} and party." For most languages that have associative plurals, they are marked on the noun the same way as "regular plurals" (which are called *additive*) are. For others, the associative number is marked differently.

Encoding number

Nearly every language marks for number using one or several of the following methods:

Most languages that have grammatical number will encode it using an affix, like Spanish:

perro	perro-s
dog	dog-PL

Whereas some others prefer to change part of the stem, like Maricopa:

hat	haat
dog	dog\PL

A handful of languages use *reduplication* to indicate plurality such as Indonesian:

anjing	anjing-anjing
dog	dog~PL

And a few others use an entirely separate word, which sometimes acts as a clitic (i.e., they follow entire noun phrases rather than just the head noun). An example of this is the plural clitic from Guaraní:

jagua	jagua	kuéra
dog	dog	=PL

And some languages don't mark number on their nouns at all, but rather leave it up to context or use a numeral (like 'six' or 'thirty-two'), quantifier (like 'some' or 'many'), or another special word. An example of this would be Cantonese, which uses a special classifier for plural nouns:

li1	jek3	gau2	li1	di1	gau2
PRX	CL	dog	PRX	CL:PL	dog

(li1 is the proximate determiner, 'this/these.' Notice that the only difference in the above example is in the classifiers jek3 and di1.)

French for instance marks the number *primarily* on the (mandatory) article, but it can show up on the noun as well.

Let's consider the example *le(s) chien(s)* meaning "the dog(s)" and, as French retained the plural marking in its orthography despite it not always being pronounced, we will indicate both orthographical and phonological information:

le	chien
lə	ʃjɛ̃
ART.DEF.SG	dog

And in the plural, this becomes:

les	chien	-s
le	ʃjɛ̃	-∅
ART.DEF.PL	dog	-PL

The plural morpheme -s of French is most often silent, but it *can* become phonologically relevant if followed by a word starting with a vowel, which would cause it to be realised as [z] in front of it in a phenomenon known as [liaison](#).

This productivity of [z] as a realisation of the plural morpheme is irregular in French.

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Of course, a combination of the above methods is also possible, like in English where some words take the plural <-s> suffix (dog/dogs), others use a stem change (foot/feet), while others aren't marked for plurality at all (sheep/sheep).

To pluralize or not to

In English, as well as in a majority of other languages, number marking is obligatory on essentially all countable nouns. However, several other languages make number marking optional unless the context doesn't already make clear how many of something there are. (Pluralization for both Indonesian and Guaraní from the examples above are optional.)

Even further than that, other languages are a little more persnickity. Some languages only have number marking available for certain groups of words, like humans or animate nouns. Sometimes number is only marked on the noun if they are definite and never marked when they're indefinite. And even in those contexts, it could still be optional.

Many languages, including English, have *mass nouns* which are uncountable. These are nouns referring to substances or concepts treated as indivisible wholes rather than collections of atomic individuals. These include collective nouns like "rice" and "traffic" and "trash" as well as abstract nouns like "respect" and "education." These cannot be pluralized. Nouns that can be pluralized, like "grain" and "car" and "teacher" are called *count nouns*.

Verbs can often take number markers as well, as can adjectives, classifiers, and any other words that agree with the number of their head noun. In Spanish, determiners, adjectives, and verbs all agree with the head noun in number:

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los      chico-s loco -s   juega -n
DET.PL boy  -PL crazy-PL play -3.PL
"The crazy boys play."
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Incorporating number

In essence, there's a lot of variation, and the number of available choices can be overwhelming when wanting to apply them to your constructed language. The key is to pursue whatever interests you the most and what aligns closest with your goals. Grammatical number can be either simple or complex.

In my main conlang, Wistanian, I've applied a very simple paradigm of grammatical number, but it's still very unusual. For a majority of countable nouns, they can take on the suffix **-n** (or **-an** if the final sound in the root is a consonant). This is technically a quantifier that means "more than five" because, if the noun is accompanied by a different quantifier, a number, or there is less than five of it, it does not decline.

ujadi	ujadi naa	ujadi-n
house	house nine	house-more.than.five
one house	nine houses	more than five houses
or 2-5	houses	

One of my design goals for Wistanian is to make it very simple and straightforward, but also kinda weird and barely naturalistic. So, this method works out well for me. If your goal is to be simple and not weird, then maybe a simple plural marker will do. If you want to be complex, then you can introduce multiple grammatical number markers and incorporate agreement. If you just don't want to deal with it, then you don't have to.